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## Traversing the “Where” Landscape: Vietnamese *đâu* and the Clausal Architecture of Vietnamese

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### Abstract:

As far as Vietnamese information-seeking questions are concerned, *đâu* is a *wh*-item equivalent to the English *where*. However, in a variety of non-canonical construals, *đâu* can be devoid of its original interrogative meaning. Specifically, we contend that pre-verbal *đâu* is a negator taking the widest scope, acting to reject the truth of a proposition/inference. Sentence-initial *đâu*, on the other hand, serves to deny or object to a discourse-salient utterance. Additionally, there are two distinct sentence-final *đâu*'s, each occupying a position in a separate domain beyond the traditional CP. One heads a Commitment Phrase, conveying the speaker's public endorsement of a contradiction to a previous statement, while the other occupies an even higher position at a Speech Act Phrase, marking the speaker's call for a specific *show-me* response from the addressee. We draw upon cross-linguistic evidence to further substantiate our claims on empirical grounds, which in turn sheds new light on the fine structure of the Vietnamese left periphery.

Keywords: *đâu*, *polarity*, *denial*, *sentence-final particle*, *syntax-pragmatics interface*, *Vietnamese*

## 1. Setting the stage

In Vietnamese information-seeking questions, *đâu* ‘where’ functions as a *wh*-expression inquiring about a location. Since Vietnamese is a *wh*-in-situ language, the interrogative *đâu* is typically found in a post-verbal position, as in (1).<sup>1</sup>

(1) Tí đi *đâu*?

Tí go where

‘Where did Tí go?’

On the other hand, it is relatively unknown in the literature that *đâu* also appears in a diverse array of contexts where its function extends far beyond a locative interpretation. Moreover, its semantic/pragmatic interpretations vary depending on its syntactic distribution. First, *đâu* can occur in two types of so-called Surprise-Denial Questions (SDQs) à la Phan & Tsai (2022). (2a) illustrates the first type of SDQs with *đâu* in a post-verbal position; (2b) shows that a similar pattern is observed with two “what” interrogative words *sao* and *gì*. SDQs are non-canonical interrogatives: they do not request information from the addressee but instead convey the speaker’s denial to a previous utterance, typically accompanied by a confrontational tone. Phan & Tsai (2022) postulate that the featured *wh*-words in SDQs are non-argumental and introduced by an implicit applicative head. The denial reading is assumed to result from a binding relation between these *wh*-words and a null operator of illocutionary force (see also Tsai 2021).

(2) a. Mưa *đâu* mà mưa!

rain ĐÂU PRT rain

‘It’s not the case that it’s raining!’

b. Mưa *gì/sao* mà mưa!

rain what PRT rain

‘It’s not the case that it’s raining!’

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<sup>1</sup> The abbreviations used in this paper are glossed as follows: 1/2/3 = first/second/third person; CL = classifier; COMP = complementizer; COP = copula; DUR = durative; FUT = future; LOC = locative; PASS = passive; PAST = past; PL = plural; PRT = particle; Q = question word; SFP = sentence-final particle; SG = singular.

The other type of SDQs features *đâu* in a sentence-initial position, see (3a). The two “what” *wh*-words *gì* and *sao* may also appear in the same position, see (3b). Phan & Tsai (2022) treat them as full-fledged adverbs merged high in CP, which no longer behave like a *wh*-pronominal (see also Phan 2023). The “recycling” of *wh*-items as markers of denial reading is attested across many languages (see Cheung 2008).<sup>2</sup>

- (3) a. **Đâu** mà mưa!  
           ĐÂU   PRT   rain  
           ‘*It’s not the case* that it’s raining!’
- b. **Gì/sao** mà mưa!  
           what   PRT   rain  
           ‘*It’s not the case* that it’s raining!’

Second, Duffield (2013) suggests that pre-verbal *đâu* might function as a “reinforcing” negative polarity item in an emphatic context, similar to the English *at all*. This instance of *đâu* is dubbed emphatic *đâu*, which “modifies—or is in construction with—a syntactic projection with negative features” (Duffield 2013: 262). Duffield takes this alleged emphatic *đâu* to be structurally related to the standard negator *không*. Specifically, *đâu* merges as specifier of a negative-related projection capable of having *không* as its head. Duffield cites (4) as evidence against the legitimate co-occurrence of *không* and *đâu*, suggesting that some additional stipulation such as Robbers’ (1992) Doubly-Filled NegP filter in (5) be invoked to filter out structures sporting two adjacent negators. We make pre-verbal *đâu* the focus of section 2, arguing that it is unrelated to negator *không* in both structural and interpretive terms.

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<sup>2</sup> Interesting cross-linguistic parallels can be found in their Chinese counterparts exemplified below:

- (i) Yu       **nali**     hui     xia!  
       rain     where   will    fall  
       ‘*It is not the case* that rain will fall!’
- (ii) **Shenme**   hui    xia     yu!  
       what     will   fall    rain  
       ‘*It is impossible* for rain to fall!’

These non-canonical *where*- and *what*-construals have been under extensive investigation in Cheung (2008), Tsai (2011, 2015), and Yang (2021), among others.

(4) a. Ông (\*không) *đâu* đến!

3SG NEG ĐÂU come

‘He did not show up!’ (Duffield 2013: 262, quoted with minor modifications)

b. Ông (\**đâu*) không đến!

3SG ĐÂU NEG come

‘He did not show up!’ (Duffield 2013: 262, quoted with minor modifications)

#### (5) Doubly Filled NegP Filter

\*[NegP n-word [Neg n-marker] [T ....]] (Robbers 1992: 230)

Duffield (2013) further likens pre-verbal *đâu* with sentence-final *đâu* as in the negative declarative of (6), at least in semantic terms. While the felicitous co-occurrence of pre-verbal *đâu* and this sentence-final *đâu* as in (7) supports their semantic compatibility, we contend that it by no means proves that they are of the same nature. This intuition can be further sharpened by paraphrasing pre-verbal *đâu* as “it’s untrue (that)...” and sentence-final *đâu* as “I’m telling you” in (7). That the two loci of *đâu* bring about distinct interpretations is also claimed in Hoàng (2003: 155–156), although his account provides no detail as to how they differ.

(6) Ông không đến *đâu*!

3SG NEG come ĐÂU

‘He is not coming/did not come!’ (simplified from Duffield 2013: 262)

(7) Tí *đâu* thích Tèo *đâu*.

Tí ĐÂU like Tèo ĐÂU

‘It’s untrue that Tí likes Tèo. I’m telling you.’

A sentence-final *đâu* is also found in interrogatives if it communicates the speaker’s request for a specific response from the addressee, as in (8), which can be paraphrased as “show me...”. We treat this instance of *đâu* as serving a *call-on-addressee* function in the sense of Beyssade & Marandin (2006), a function which, to the best of our knowledge, has not been previously studied. For reasons to be clarified later, we take these sentence-final *đâu*’s to occupy two distinct projections in the topmost domain above the traditional CP.

(8) Tí là ai **đâu**?

Tí be who ĐÂU

‘Who is Tí? *Show me!*’

All in all, this paper aims to explore the landscape of *đâu* in Vietnamese, focusing on its distinct syntactic and interpretive properties in pre-verbal, sentence-initial, and sentence-final positions. The proposed analysis contributes further to ongoing efforts aimed at achieving a finer-grained understanding of Vietnamese functional architecture from the vantage point of syntactic cartography. The roadmap for this paper is as follows. Section 2 distinguishes pre-verbal *đâu* (henceforth POL-*đâu*) from both standard negator *không* and sentence-initial *đâu*, arguing that only POL-*đâu* takes the widest scope of negation. Section 3 contends that sentence-final *đâu* in negative declaratives (hereafter DEC-*đâu*) cannot be likened to POL-*đâu*, as it does not mark negation but rather publicly registers the speaker’s commitment to a proposition containing a wide-scope negation. Section 4 makes a case for sentence-final *đâu* in interrogatives (hereafter INT-*đâu*), arguing that it communicates a specific instruction on how the addressee should respond to the speaker’s question. Section 5 concludes the paper.

## 2. POL-*đâu* and negation

Despite its universal presence, negation exhibits significant variation across different languages. This section delves into the syntactic distribution and interpretive nuances of POL-*đâu* as a negative element, first contrasting it with the more conventional negator *không*. We analyze *không* and POL-*đâu* as markers of distinct types of negation, diverging from Duffield’s (2013) claim that *đâu* modifies or is in construction with a polarity phrase headed by *không*. We will distinguish these two markers of negation both structurally (section 2.1) and interpretively (section 2.2).

### 2.1 Negation above TP?

It is noteworthy that, *pace* Duffield (2013), (4b) with POL-*đâu* scoping over *không* (repeated here as (9b)) is in fact well-formed when interpreted as ‘*It’s untrue* that he did not show up.’ This indicates that the two negators are not truly in complementary distribution. Attested examples of this co-occurrence in (10-11) further support this observation. That (9a) is ill-formed

while (9b) and (10-11) are acceptable suggests that *đâu* and *không* may co-occur if the former precedes and therefore merges above the latter.

(9) a. Ông (\*không) **đâu** đến!

3SG NEG ĐÂU come

‘He did not show up!’ (Duffield 2013: 262, quoted with minor modifications)

b. Ông (\***đâu**) không đến!

3SG ĐÂU NEG come

‘He did not show up!’ (Duffield 2013: 262, quoted with minor modifications)

(10) Tôi **đâu** không biết chăm sóc anh ấy<sup>3</sup>

1SG ĐÂU NEG know look.after 3SG

‘It’s *untrue* that I don’t know how to look after him’

(11) A: Chẳng có ai ở đây ưa anh cả.

NEG have who at here like 2SG at.all

‘No one here likes you at all.’

B: Không, không, họ **đâu** có không ưa tôi. Họ chỉ khinh thường tôi thôi.<sup>45</sup>

NEG NEG 3PL ĐÂU have NEG like 1SG 3PL just despise 1SG only

‘No, no, it’s *untrue* that they don’t like me. They just despise me.’

If POL-*đâu* and *không* are structurally unrelated, we expect to see disparities in their interactions with other elements in the clause. This expectation is confirmed by the contrast in (12): only *không*, and never POL-*đâu*, can scope under universal quantifiers such as *cũng* ‘also’ and *đều* ‘all’.

(12) a. Ai cũng **không**/\***đâu** đến.

who also NEG ĐÂU come

‘No one comes.’

<sup>3</sup> <https://kinhtedothi.vn/cau-chuyen-khong-muon-ke.html>

<sup>4</sup> [http://www.chanphuocliem.com/Trang\\_ThuVienSach/ttt\\_HauBoGia1.asp](http://www.chanphuocliem.com/Trang_ThuVienSach/ttt_HauBoGia1.asp)

<sup>5</sup> Strictly speaking, the presence of *có* (lit. ‘have’) immediately following *đâu* is optional. We leave open in this study the exact nature of *có*, a multifunctional element in Vietnamese.

- b. Cả Tí lẫn Tèo đều **không**/\***đâu** đến.  
 both Tí and Tèo all NEG ĐÂU come  
 ‘Neither Tí nor Tèo comes.’

Evidence against lumping POL-*đâu* and *không* in one projection further arises from their differing linear positions relative to tense-marking items. For example, past-tense marker *đã* always precedes *không* (Trinh 2005; Phan 2013, a.o.) but follows POL-*đâu*, as shown in (13a) and (13b) respectively. The low merge position of *không* is expected under the assumption that it projects a (low) Polarity Phrase below TP but above viewpoint aspect markers (Duffield 2013; Phan 2013), thereby realizing standard negation à la Payne (1985).<sup>6</sup> In Klima’s (1964) terms, this is a case of *sentence* negation. Note that *không* can also realize *constituent* negation—the other type of negation in Klima’s framework—if it follows these high aspect markers, as illustrated by the contrast in (14).<sup>7</sup>

- (13) a. Tí đã **không** {*\*đã*} ăn sáng. [T > *không*]

Tí PAST NEG PAST eat morning

‘Tí did *not* have breakfast.’

- b. Tí {*\*đã*} **đâu** {*đã*} ăn sáng. [*đâu* > T]

Tí PAST ĐÂU PAST eat morning

‘*It’s untrue* that Tí had breakfast.’

- (14) a. Tôi **không** đang ăn cơm. [Neg > Asp: sentence negation]

I SG NEG DUR eat rice

- b. Tôi đang **không** ăn cơm. [Asp > Neg: constituent negation]

I SG DUR NEG eat rice

‘I am not having a meal.’

(Phan 2013: 74-75; quoted with minor modifications)

<sup>6</sup> The observation that TP precedes and takes scope over NegP goes back to Pollock (1989).

<sup>7</sup> For clarity, we by default mean *không* as a marker of sentence negation when it is mentioned in comparison against *đâu* in this study.

That POL-*đâu* must precede *đã* suggests that the former merges externally to TP. We identify this projection as High Polarity Phrase (HPolP) above TP; the TP-internal projection hosting sentence negator *không* is subsequently relabeled as Low Polarity Phrase (LPolP).<sup>8</sup> The presence of (at least) three scopally distinct negators in Vietnamese, as shown in (15), challenges the adequacy of Klima's (1964) classic sentence/constituent dichotomy of negation, necessitating a finer-grained distinction between means of marking negation in the language. We nevertheless will continue to use the term *sentence negation* to collectively refer to POL-*đâu* and non-constituent *không* when their differences are not relevant.

(15) [HPolP **POL-*đâu*** [TP *đã* [LPolP *không* [AspP *đang* [vP ... *không* ...]]]]<sup>9</sup>

A side note is in order. It is important to acknowledge that, in principle, *đã* can be interpreted as either a past tense marker or a perfect aspect marker, with the latter merging below *không* (Trinh 2005; Phan 2013). To ensure we are testing POL-*đâu* against tense-marking *đã*, we need to consider environments where *đã* necessarily has a past interpretation. The co-occurrence of *đã* with a succeeding adverb *từng* 'once' ensures this, as demonstrated by the contrast in (16).<sup>10</sup>

- (16) a. Lá ***đã*** vàng.  
 leaf ĐÃ yellow  
 'Leaves were yellow.' [*đã*: past]  
 'Leaves have turned yellow.' [*đã*: perfect]
- b. Lá ***đã*** *từng* vàng.  
 leaf ĐÃ once yellow  
 'Leaves were once yellow.' [*đã*: past]

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<sup>8</sup> Polarity is understood here as a more abstract syntactic category which includes negation and affirmation in complementary distribution (Laka 1990). Following Progovac (2005), we assume that the default or unmarked specification for PolP is positive, and the negative specification must be overtly marked by a negative element.

<sup>9</sup> We set aside the exact structural position of constituent negator *không* in our discussion. The crucial point here is that high *không* and low *không* exhibit a clear scopal difference relative to (viewpoint) aspect markers.

<sup>10</sup> An anonymous reviewer inquires about the derivation of the order *đã từng* 'PAST once'. One possible explanation is to assume that *từng* merges in the specifier of the Outer Aspect Phrase headed by the aspectual marker *đã* (cf. Phan 2013). After *đã* raises to TP to derive the past-tense reading, the observed linear ordering arises.

Given that the co-occurrence of *đã* and *từng* ensures the past reading of the former, the naturally occurring examples in (17) demonstrate that *đâu* indeed precedes tense markers, thereby merging above TP. This provides clear evidence for the structural distinction between TP-external *đâu* and TP-level *không*.

- (17) a. họ **đâu** đã từng đi đến vùng Dải Chiêng hay đã từng vượt qua  
 3PL ĐÂU PAST once go arrive region D.C. or PAST once cross pass  
 truong Phường Rạnh như tôi<sup>11</sup>  
 grassland P.R. like 1SG  
 ‘they didn’t once travel to the D.C. region or once passed the P.R. grassland like me’
- b. Mới chỉ phút giây tao ngộ, họ **đâu** đã từng vào sinh ra tử  
 just only moment encounter 3PL ĐÂU PAST once go.in alive go.out die  
 với nhau<sup>12</sup>  
 with each.other  
 ‘Only encountering each other for a short while, they didn’t once go through water and fire together’
- c. nó **đâu** đã từng học ai để biết phải cạo gió cách nào<sup>13</sup>  
 3SG ĐÂU PAST once learn who so.that know must scrape wind way which  
 ‘He didn’t once learn from anyone to understand how to *guasha*’

The high merge position of POL-*đâu* relative to TP-level elements is further supported when future marker *sẽ* enters the equation. Specifically, *sẽ* precedes *không* (Phan 2013), while it must always follow *đâu*, see (18).

- (18) a. nhưng bạn thân mến của tôi, niềm vui ấy **đâu** sẽ kéo dài mãi<sup>14</sup>  
 but friend dear POSS 1SG CL happy that ĐÂU FUT pull long forever  
 ‘But my dear friend, *it’s untrue* that that happiness will go on forever’

<sup>11</sup> <https://phamxuandai.blogspot.com/2016/12/phat-bieu-ve-tap-tho-tat-can-oi-song.html>

<sup>12</sup> <http://tapchisonghuong.com.vn/tin-tuc/p5/c47/n971/Chiec-bai-nga-phieu-lang-1.html>

<sup>13</sup> <https://gxdaminh.net/ba-nguoi-ban-khong-ten/>

<sup>14</sup> <https://ybox.vn/share-link/triet-hoc-tuoi-tre/vai-loi-tam-su-ve-viec-chon-truong-63da0891e210476d7fdff4bc>

- b. Cái trò năng lượng này sau này nó **đâu** sẽ chỉ là chuyện làm ăn.<sup>15</sup>  
 CL game energy this later this 3SG ĐÂU FUT only COP affair business  
 ‘As for this energy game, in the future *it’s untrue* that it will only be a matter of business.’

Another piece of evidence for the TP-external position of POL-*đâu* comes from embedding facts. First, *không* can be embedded under both non-factive verbs (such as *nghĩ* ‘think’) and factive verbs (such as *hối hận* ‘regret’), while POL-*đâu* only allows embedding under non-factive predicates. See the contrast in (19).

- (19) a. Tí nghĩ là Mai **không/đâu** thích mình. [non-factive predicate]  
 Tí think COMP Mai NEG ĐÂU like self  
 ‘Tí thinks that Mai doesn’t like him.’  
 b. Tí hối hận **không/\*đâu** dạy con tự lập sớm. [factive predicate]  
 Tí regret NEG ĐÂU teach child independent early  
 ‘Tí regrets not to teach his child to be independent early.’

Second, both *không* and POL-*đâu* may appear in a peripheral adverbial clause (PAC), like the one introduced by the concessive *dù* ‘although’ in (20a). In contrast, only *không* is permissible within a central adverbial clause (CAC) such as the temporal *khi*-clause in (20b). The distinction between PAC and CAC goes back to Haegeman (1984), with CAC being more syntactically integrated to (that is, more deeply embedded within) the host clause (see Frey 2023). The unrestricted embeddability of *không* qualifies it as a non-root phenomenon. On the other hand, POL-*đâu* shows its true nature as a root phenomenon, given the constraints on its embedding contexts.<sup>16</sup> To foreshadow, we will adopt a finer-grained distinction between two types of root phenomena in section 2.5, where we compare POL-*đâu* and sentence-initial *đâu*.

- (20) a. Tí bị Tèo mắng [dù nó **không/đâu** làm gì.] [*although*-clause]  
 Tí PASS Tèo scold although 3SG NEG ĐÂU do what  
 ‘Tí was scolded by Tèo although he didn’t do anything.’

<sup>15</sup> <https://voz.vn/t/ngay-cang-dat-do-dubai-dang-tren-da-thanh-monaco-thu-2.749642/>

<sup>16</sup> Non-root phenomena are linguistic phenomena that occur in all kinds of clauses, whereas root phenomena (also known as main-clause phenomena) are observed in root clauses and a limited set of “root-like” dependent clauses. For an overview of root phenomena, see Aelbrecht et al. (2012).

- b. Tí bị Tèo mắng [khi nó *không*/\**đâu* làm việc.] [*when*-clause]  
 Tí PASS Tèo scold although 3SG NEG ĐÂU do job  
 ‘Tí was scolded by Tèo when he didn’t work.’

We interpret these embedding facts as evidence of the differing hierarchical positions of *không* and *đâu* along the functional spine. Specifically, under a “structural deficiency” analysis, where the complement clauses of factive verbs and central adverbial clauses are assumed to project only to TP (Frey 2018, 2023; Badan & Haegeman 2022), the merging of *không* below TP and POL-*đâu* above it would straightforwardly explain the acceptable presence of *không* but not POL-*đâu* in (18b) and (19b). On the other hand, the complement of non-factive verbs and adverbial clauses of the peripheral type have a bigger size as they project to CP (Frey & Meinunger 2019; Badan & Haegeman 2022; Frey 2023), enabling them to accommodate the TP-external *đâu*.

The existence of a TP-external projection hosting negative elements and the co-occurrence of two or more projections hosting negative markers are in fact attested cross-linguistically. As early as Lasnik (1972), it was suggested that negative markers may be base-generated in more than one position within the clause structure. Ouhalla’s (1990) NEG Parameter proposes that Negative Phrase may vary between languages, selecting either VP or TP as its complement. Laka (1990) argues that Basque negation is generated above TP in PolP, an independent functional projection where negative or affirmative polarity values are encoded. Zanuttini (1997) provides evidence from Romance varieties spoken in Northern Italy, demonstrating four distinct projections hosting negative markers, with the highest being TP-external. This supports Progovac’s (2005) claim that a clause may contain multiple Polarity Phrases if needed.

## 2.2 Two types of sentence negation

We suggest that the structural difference in merge position between *không* (TP-internal) and POL-*đâu* (TP-external) correlates with disparities in their interpretation and felicity conditions. Given its TP-external position, POL-*đâu* appears to realize negation of the widest scope: it marks a propositional attitude of rejection (cf. Horn & Wansing 2022), taking as false a discourse-old

proposition or inference (i.e, an implicature emerging out of the preceding discourse).<sup>17</sup> In contrast, negation with *không* can express discourse-new information and simply describe a state of affairs without reference to a pre-established proposition of any shape or form. The fact that only *không* may occur in a description of a state of affairs without reference to a prior proposition makes it appropriate in response to global questions such as “What happened?”. This explains why *không*, but not POL-*đâu*, is felicitous in the context of (21): given the lack of a discourse-prominent proposition like ‘Today’s lunch is tasty’, only the use of standard negator *không* is felicitous.

(21) Context: *A mother asked her child if he had something to share about his day at school. He replies...*

Com    trưa    hôm nay    ***không***<sup>#</sup>*đâu*    ngon.  
 rice    noon    today    NEG    ĐÂU    tasty  
 ‘Today’s lunch was not tasty.’

In contrast, when there is a need to cancel an inference, only *đâu* is felicitous (see 22).

(22) Context: *A thanks B for his help. B replies...*

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<sup>17</sup> Duffield’s (2013) characterization of *đâu* as a negation reinforcer is also less than satisfactory. First, it is unclear what emphasizing effect(s) POL-*đâu* has on the interpretation of its host clause. This concern echoes Schwenter’s (2005: 1429–30) remarks in his discussion of three ways of encoding negation in Brazilian Portuguese, where he states that “emphasis is an intuitive label that is most typically left undefined,” and “invoking emphasis as a semantic–pragmatic explanation is of little use without an accompanying definition, since its intuitive nature makes it virtually unfalsifiable.” Moreover, while English *at all* is a negative polarity item (NPI), POL-*đâu* is not. An equivalent of English *at all* is *hề*, of which either *không* or POL-*đâu* may act as a c-commanding licenser, see (i). Even if we accept that *at all* and *hề* can mark emphatic negation, the natural co-occurrence of *đâu* and *hề* as in (ib) undermines the characterization of POL-*đâu* as a reinforcer of negation.

(i) a. Tí    **\*(*không*)**    *hề*    đến.

Tí    NEG    at.all    come  
 ‘Tí did not show up at all.’

b. Tí    **\*(*đâu*)**    *hề*    đến.

Tí    ĐÂU    at.all    come

‘It’s not at all true that Tí showed up.’

Sao cảm ơn em? Em **đâu**/ <sup>#</sup>**không** giúp được gì cho anh.  
 why thank 1SG 1SG ĐÂU NEG help gain what for 2SG  
 ‘Why thank me? *It’s untrue* that I managed to do anything for you.’

It is crucial to note that an utterance hosting POL-*đâu* is also felicitous as a conversation starter in out-of-the-blue contexts, provided the context is non-neutral. Bill & Koev (2021: 190) remark that a verum-marked declarative can appear in out-of-the-blue contexts “if an epistemic conflict can easily be accommodated.” Importantly, the use of POL-*đâu* can be accommodated simply by the speaker’s own anticipation of a potential proposition which she would take as false. Namely, the speaker can justifiably employ *đâu* if she believes that some others might hold a view contradictory to her not-yet-voiced belief, exhibiting what we dub ‘preemptive’ negation. In (23), *đâu* is felicitous in a conversation starter because A could imagine B being perceived as a smoker by other people, although A personally biases towards B not smoking (potentially due to some piece of evidence available to A at the time of speaking).

(23) Context: *After lighting his cigarette, A caught B, a stranger, looking at him as they stood at the bus stop. A then asked...*

Anh **đâu** hút thuốc ha?  
 2SG ĐÂU smoke SFP

‘You don’t smoke, right? (= I assume *it’d be untrue* that you smoke, but please confirm.)’

Similarly, the woman in (24) is aware that her rejection of the proposition *p* ‘Her husband understands how much she longs for weekends off’ as false might be contentious (i.e. she could imagine certain people might simply assume *p*). Given the potential epistemic conflict in this context, the use of POL-*đâu* is felicitous.

(24) Context: *A woman is complaining that her husband always forces her to return to his parents’ house with him every weekend...*

Người quanh năm ở nhà như anh **đâu** hiểu được tôi khao khát  
 person around year at home like you ĐÂU understand can 1SG long.for  
 ngày nghỉ cuối tuần thế nào.<sup>18</sup>

<sup>18</sup> <https://vietnamnet.vn/vo-phan-don-gat-khi-bi-nguoi-chong-an-bam-day-cach-lam-dau-2201809.html>

day rest end week like how

‘Someone who stays at home all year round like him can’t understand how much I long for weekends off. (= *It’d be untrue* to assume someone like him would understand that.)’

In both (23) and (24), the use of POL-*đâu* communicates that a relevant attitude holder, while anticipating that certain people might float the idea of some *p*, decides to proceed with  $\neg p$  as she is epistemically biased against *p*.<sup>19</sup> Overall, POL-*đâu* inherently targets the truth value of a proposition *p*, irrespective of whether *p* is salient in the preceding discourse or conjured up solely in the speaker’s mind at the time of utterance.

The importance of a potential epistemic conflict for the licensing of POL-*đâu* is further illustrated with (25-27), where only *không* is felicitous. A non-biased polar question such as (25) provides no evidence supporting the speaker’s belief that the other participant is epistemically inclined towards the truth of either of the two possibilities. In (26), the prior context presents a proposition as a mere possibility without any epistemic inclination. In (27), the response is intended simply as a (weak) confirmation of a previous proposition. For POL-*đâu* to be used felicitously, the truth value of a *p* must be at stake: by employing POL-*đâu*, the speaker takes issue with the truth of *p*, claiming that *p* does not hold in the actual world.<sup>20</sup>

(25) Context: *A and B are playing a guessing game and at one point A must check whether the character Tí has a fondness for other characters. There is a checklist of these characters including Tèo, which A is going through...*

A: Tí thích Tèo không?

Tí like Tèo NEG

‘Does Tí like Tèo? (I have no idea, please inform me.)’

B: Tí *không*<sup>#</sup> *đâu* thích Tèo.

Tí NEG ĐÂU like Tèo

‘Tí does not like Tèo.’

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<sup>19</sup> An attitude holder is understood as either the absolute/external speaker of the speech situation or the matrix subject, also known as the relative/internal speaker.

<sup>20</sup> Conversely, POL-*đâu* is entirely natural when responding to declaratives, *wh*-questions, and biased *yes/no* questions.

(26) A: Tí có thể là người Việt hoặc không.

Tí can be person Vietnam or NEG

‘Tí can be Vietnamese or not.’

B: Tí *không* /<sup>#</sup>*đâu* phải người Việt.

Tí NEG ĐÂU correct person Vietnam

‘Tí isn’t Vietnamese.’

(27) A: Tí không phải người Việt.

Tí NEG correct person Vietnam

‘Tí isn’t Vietnamese.’

B: Vâng, Tí quả thực *không* /<sup>#</sup>*đâu* phải người Việt.

yes Tí indeed NEG ĐÂU correct person Vietnam

‘Yes, Tí is indeed not Vietnamese.’

Furthermore, since POL-*đâu* concerns the speaker’s mental attitude towards the truth value of a proposition, it is unsuitable for use in a prohibitive context like (28), where there is no proposition whose truth value can be contested. In contrast, *không* works well in such contexts.

(28) *Không* /<sup>\*</sup>*đâu* được lại đây!

NEG ĐÂU can come here

‘Don’t come here!’ (= ‘You are not allowed to come here.’)

The previous discussion also reveals that *đâu* consistently anchors to an attitude holder. This property is shared with mood and modal elements like *có lẽ* ‘perhaps’ and *chắc chắn* ‘surely’ at the lower end of the left periphery (Phan 2024). Unsurprisingly, POL-*đâu* also parallels these elements in terms of embedding. Similar to POL-*đâu*, CP-level mood and modal markers in Vietnamese are only embedded within PACs (29a) and the complements of non-factive predicates (30a); they are however excluded from CACs (29b) and the clause selected by factive predicates (30b).<sup>21</sup> This parallel further supports the high position of POL-*đâu* in the functional spine, distinguishing it with TP-internal *không*, which is independent of an attitude holder and can be freely embedded.

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<sup>21</sup> See Phan 2024 (chapter 6) for more discussion on these markers.

- (29) a. Tí còn giận [dù Tèo *có lẽ/ chắc chắn* đã xin lỗi].  
 Tí still angry although Tèo perhaps surely PAST apologize  
 ‘Tí is still mad although Tèo *perhaps/surely* already apologized.’
- b. \*Tí còn giận [khi Tèo *có lẽ/ chắc chắn* xin lỗi].  
 Tí still angry when Tèo perhaps surely apologize
- (30) a. Tí nghĩ [*có lẽ/ chắc chắn* Tèo sẽ đến].  
 Tí think perhaps surely Tèo FUT come  
 ‘Tí thinks that Tèo *perhaps/surely* will come.’
- b. \*Tí *hối hận* [*có lẽ/ chắc chắn* đã đến].  
 Tí regret perhaps surely PAST come

### 2.3 A comparative perspective

Interestingly, distinctions between negators reminiscent of the POL-*đâu/không* dichotomy are also observed in other languages. Zanuttini (1997) claims that of the two Piedmontese negative markers *pa* and *nen*, the former precedes the TP-adverb *gia* ‘already’ (31) but the latter follows it (32), indicating that *pa* is structurally higher than *nen*. See (33) for an illustration. In interpretive terms, Zanuttini claims that *pa* is typically associated with a presuppositional reading (marked with the diacritic @ in the translation), meaning that the negated proposition must be assumed in the discourse. In contrast, *nen* is free of this restriction, negating a proposition with no specific discourse status.<sup>22</sup> *Pa* thus behaves similarly to *đâu*, whereas *nen* parallels *không*.

- (31) A l’è *pa* gia parti.  
 s.cl. s.cl.’is neg already left  
 ‘@He hasn’t already left.’ (Zanuttini 1997a: 69)
- (32) A l’avai gia *nen* salutami cul di là.  
 s.cl. s.cl.’had already not greeted-me that day there  
 ‘Already on that day he had not greeted me.’ (Zanuttini 1997a: 70)

<sup>22</sup> The distinction is somewhat reminiscent of the complementary distribution between *no*-negation (favored in discourse-new contexts) and *not*-negation (typically found in discourse-old contexts) in English as discussed in Childs (2017).

(33) [NegP *pa* Neg<sup>o</sup> [TP *gia* T<sup>o</sup> [NegP *nen* Neg<sup>o</sup> [AspP ... (adapted from Zanuttini 1997: 74)

Structurally and interpretively, POL-*đâu* is also reminiscent of what De Clercq (2013) terms negative polarity (Pol<sup>Neg</sup>) markers. These polarity markers are sandwiched between a higher FinP and a lower TP, taking scope over tensed predicates and thus the entire proposition, including the subject. This results in propositional negation (Horn 1989), which can be paraphrased as ‘It is not the case that...’. De Clercq considers Klima’s (1964) English question (reverse polarity) tag-test, as shown in (34), to be a reliable way of testing sentential negative polarity, i.e. to determine whether a negative marker is a Pol<sup>Neg</sup>-marker.<sup>23</sup> The patterns in (34) are interpreted as follows: with *n’t* preceding *often* in (34a), the positive question tag indicates the sentence’s negative value; when *often* precedes *n’t* in (34b), the strictly negative tag indicates that the sentence is affirmative.

(34) a. John does*n’t* often pay taxes, does he/\*doesn’t he? (Neg-S)

b. John often does*n’t* pay taxes, \*does he/doesn’t he? (Aff-S)

(De Clercq 2013: 140)

Payne (1985: 200) uses the possibility to paraphrase a sentence as *I say (of X) that it is not true that Y* as a diagnostic for sentential negation and subsequently claims that (34a), but not (34b), demonstrates a case of sentential negation. This is because only (34a) can be paraphrased as *I say of John that it is not true that he often pays taxes*. On the other hand, *n’t* in (34b) fits the description of *predicate negation* à la De Clercq (2013). This type of negation scopes below TP, taking scope only over the untensed predicate (but not over the tensed predicate, unlike Pol<sup>Neg</sup>-markers), roughly corresponding to the standard negation marked by *không*.<sup>24</sup>

## 2.4 The widest scope of negation

Section 2.3 previously suggested that POL-*đâu* takes a wider scope of negation compared to *không*. Whether it has the widest scope of negation is however still undetermined, given that *đâu* can occur sentence-initially, as seen in (35). This section demonstrates that sentence-initial *đâu* is

<sup>23</sup> The test is adapted from Payne (1985).

<sup>24</sup> For completeness’ sake, negative markers might also scope over only a predicate term, in which case they mark *predicate term negation* in the sense of De Clercq (2013). This corresponds to constituent negation in Klima’s (1964) terminology, which *không* can also indicate if merged below aspect markers.

distinct from POL-*đâu*, with the former having a wider scope. Nonetheless, only POL-*đâu* qualifies as a negative marker. This effectively reaffirms POL-*đâu* as the negator that takes the widest scope.

(35) *Đâu* mà mưa! (= (3))

ĐÂU PRT rain

‘*It’s not the case* that it’s raining! (= *I deny it* that it’s raining!)’

Sentence-initial *đâu* differs from POL-*đâu* in several aspects. Sentence-initial *đâu* appears at the beginning of the sentence, while POL-*đâu* generally follows the subject. Additionally, only sentence-initial *đâu* is followed by modal particle *mà*, as shown in (35). Phan (2024) identifies *mà* as the head of a Particle Phrase that merges above a range of CP-level projections hosting mood and modal (ad)verbs. In contrast, POL-*đâu* merges below these mood and modal elements, as evidenced by its linear placement relative to epistemic *có lẽ* ‘perhaps’ in (36a) and evidential *rõ ràng* ‘clearly’ in (36b).

(36) a. *có lẽ* họ *đâu* muốn dạy “láo lếu” như thế<sup>25</sup>

perhaps 3PL ĐÂU want teach dishonest like so

‘Perhaps *it’s untrue* that they wanted to teach such dishonest things’

b. *Rõ ràng* nó *đâu* có lỗi.<sup>26</sup>

clearly 3SG ĐÂU have fault

‘Clearly *it’s untrue* that he did anything wrong.’

The scopal disparity between the two is further demonstrated through their interaction with certain adverbial clauses, such as *if*- or *because*-clauses. Specifically, POL-*đâu* can have either a narrow or wide scope relative to a reason *vì*-clause, whereas sentence-initial *đâu* always takes scope over it.<sup>27</sup> See (37) and (38), adapted from Martins (2021: 180), for the contrast.

<sup>25</sup> <http://www.nuiansongtra.com/index.php?c=article&p=8121>

<sup>26</sup> <https://www.sggp.org.vn/dung-luom-ve-so-post657705.html>

<sup>27</sup> An anonymous reviewer suggests that (38) might also allow the reverse scopal relation. We contend that such a reading can only (marginally) be entertained if the reason clause is separated from the main clause by a prosodic break, constituting a case of non-integrated dependent clause, a type of “syntactic orphan” à la Haegeman 1991/2009 (see also Frey 2023).

(37) Tí *đâu* ở tù vì nó đã cho lời khai giả.

Tí ĐÂU at jail because 3SG PAST give testimony fake

a. ‘It’s because Tí gave a false testimony that he’s not in jail. (*It’s untrue* that he is.)’

[*because* > POL-*đâu*]

b. ‘It’s not because Tí gave a false testimony that he’s in jail. (*It’s untrue* that it is.)’

[POL-*đâu* > *because*]

(38) *Đâu* mà Tí ở tù vì nó đã cho lời khai giả.

ĐÂU PRT Tí at jail because 3SG PAST give testimony fake

‘*I deny it* that it is because Tí gave a false testimony that he is in jail.’ [SI *đâu* > *because*]

We attribute the scopal ambiguity in (37-38) to the possibility of a reason clause (or a conditional clause) appearing either as a peripheral adverbial clause (PAC) or a central adverbial clause (CAC), a phenomenon widely attested cross-linguistically (see Endo & Haegeman 2019; Frey 2023; Phan 2024, and citations therein). These two types of adjuncts correspond to two structural positions. Frey (2023) posits that PACs merge in Krifka’s (2017, 2023) Judge Phrase, which Badan & Haegeman (2022) consider the ‘telescoped’ variant of a range of CP-level mood/modal projections à la Cinque (1999). CACs, on the other hand, are more deeply embedded as TP-adjuncts. Consequently, the scopal ambiguity, as previously mentioned, should come as no surprise if we accept that POL-*đâu* projects above TP but below these CP-level mood/modal phrases. Sentence-initial *đâu*, in contrast, merges above this mood/modal field, allowing it to always take wide scope over both PACs and CACs.

Another difference between sentence-initial *đâu* and POL-*đâu* lies in the items that form paradigms with them. To wit, sentence-initially *đâu* can be replaced with *gì* and *sao*, two adverbs whose origins trace back to *what*-denoting pronominals (see (3)); POL-*đâu*, on the contrary, can be substituted only by *nào* (lit. ‘which’).<sup>28</sup> See (39) for an attested example and (40) for a distributional contrast.

(39) Context (excerpt from a short story): *The young lady crossed many mountains calling for her lover until her voice turned hoarse...*

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<sup>28</sup> Unlike POL-*đâu*, *nào* is most fitting in more literary contexts.

nhưng chàng ở xa **nào** có hay biết.<sup>29</sup>

but man at far which have aware know

‘but since the young man was far away, he was totally unaware (of her calling for him).’

(40) a. **Đâu/ gì/sao/\*nào** mà mưa!

ĐÂU what which PRT rain

‘It’s not the case that it’s raining! (= I deny it that it’s raining!)’

b. Trời **đâu/ nào/ \*gì/\*sao** mưa.

sky ĐÂU which what rain

‘It’s untrue that it’s raining!’

POL-*đâu* and sentence-initial *đâu* also differ in the sentence-final particles they may co-occur with. Specifically, while POL-*đâu* is compatible with a sentence-final *đâu* in declaratives (to be returned to in section 3), sentence-initial *đâu* does not. Instead, it can be paired with sentence-final *được* to maximize naturalness (see Phan & Meisterernst To appear).

(41) a. Tí **đâu** thích Tèo đâu/\*được.

Tí ĐÂU like Tèo SFP SFP

‘It’s untrue that Tí likes Tèo. I’m telling you.’

b. **Đâu** mà Tí thích Tèo được/\*đâu.

ĐÂU PRT Tí like Tèo SFP SFP

‘It’s not the case that Tí likes Tèo. I don’t believe he does.’

In interpretive terms, sentence-initial *đâu* has a clear denial reading, functioning to deny or object to a discourse-salient utterance; as a negator, POL-*đâu* challenges the truth of a proposition rather than targeting the utterance expressing it. Since sentence-initial *đâu* must deny a previous utterance, it is found only in responding assertions and never in initiating assertions (in the sense of Farkas & Bruce 2010). In contrast, POL-*đâu* can appear in both types of assertions, provided there is a discourse-salient proposition (or inference) to be negated. In the out-of-the-blue context in (23), repeated as (42), the use of sentence-initial *đâu* is infelicitous due to the absence of a previous utterance to be denied.

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<sup>29</sup> <https://www.baohoabinh.com.vn/40/76710/Ve-mien-Tay-Bac-nghe-chuyen-tinh-hoa-ban.htm>

(42) Context: *After lighting his cigarette, A caught B, a stranger, looking at him as they stood at the bus stop. A then asked...*

a. Anh **đâu** hút thuốc ha?

2SG ĐÂU smoke SFP

‘You don’t smoke, right? (= I assume *it’d be untrue* that you smoke, but please confirm.)’

b. #**Đâu** mà anh hút thuốc ha?

ĐÂU PRT 2SG smoke SFP

Int: ‘*I deny it* that you smoke, but please confirm.’

We hypothesize, following Phan & Tsai (2022) and Tsai (2008), that the denial reading of sentence-initial *đâu* is derived from its association with an illocutionary force of denial; thus, it should be unrelated to negative polarity. Evidence for the non-negative nature of sentence-initial *đâu* comes from its behavior concerning Horn’s (1989) polarity item test (see also van der Sandt 1991). The test indicates that if an element is a negative marker, it licenses negative polarity items (NPIs) but is incompatible with positive polarity items (PPIs) within its c-command domain. POL-*đâu* passes this test with flying colors: it licenses NPIs like *hề* ‘at all’, *bao giờ* ‘ever’ (43a) and *một ai* ‘anyone’/ *một cái gì* ‘anything’ (43b) while being barred from co-occurring with PPIs like *ai đó* ‘someone’/ *cái gì đó* ‘something’ and *vẫn* ‘still’ to its right (44).

(43) POL-*đâu* > NPI

a. Tí **đâu** bao giờ/ hề đến.

Tí ĐÂU ever at.all come

‘It’s never true/ not true at all that he’s come.’

b. Tí **đâu** thấy một ai/ một cái gì.

Tí ĐÂU see anyone anything

‘It’s *untrue* that he saw anyone/anything.’

(44) \*POL-*đâu* > PPI

a. \*Tí **đâu** thấy ai đó/ cái gì đó.

Tí ĐÂU see someone something

b. \*Tí **đâu** vẫn ngủ.

Tí ĐÂU still sleep

Sentence-initial *đâu* exhibits the opposite behavior: it is unable to license NPIs (45) and also does not affect PPIs (46), revealing its true nature as a non-negator. This effectively leaves POL-*đâu* as the element with the widest scope of negation.

(45) \*SI *đâu* > NPI

a. \***Đâu** mà Tí bao giờ/ hề đến. [\*SI *đâu* > NPI]

ĐÂU PRT Tí ever at.all come

b. \***Đâu** mà Tí ngủ chút nào. [\*SI *đâu* > NPI]

ĐÂU PRT Tí sleep bit which

(46) SI *đâu* > PPI

a. **Đâu** mà Tí thấy ai đó/ cái gì đó.

ĐÂU PRT Tí see someone something

‘*I deny it that Tí sees someone/something.*’

b. **Đâu** mà Tí vẫn ngủ.

ĐÂU PRT Tí still sleep

‘*I deny it that Tí is still sleeping.*’

## 2.5 A note on two types of root phenomena

POL-*đâu* and sentence-initial *đâu* also behave differently when embedding facts are concerned. As (47) shows, while POL-*đâu* can be embedded inside the complement clause of a non-factive predicate, sentence-initial *đâu* is strictly excluded from all embedding contexts. The behavior of sentence-initial *đâu* aligns with that of Cantonese sentence-initial *bindou* ‘where’ as reported in Cheung (2008), see (48). Cheung (2008) claims that the negative *wh*-constructions in 19 out of 20 languages in his survey (Vietnamese not included) exhibit this behavior. Martins (2021) also claims that certain *wh*-words expressing denial such as Brazilian Portuguese *qual* (lit. ‘which’) as in (49) also resist embedding. Recall that in section 2.1, we considered POL-*đâu* to be a root phenomenon. Comparing POL-*đâu* against sentence-initial *đâu* in terms of embedding reveals that a root/non-root dichotomy falls short of fully capturing their distinct natures.

(47) a. *Tí nghĩ/ tin là Tèo **đâu** ăn cơm.* [POL-*đâu*]

*Tí think believe COMP Tèo ĐÂU eat rice*

‘*Tí thinks/believes it’s untrue that Tèo eats rice.*’

b. \**Tí nghĩ/ tin là **đâu** mà Tèo ăn cơm.* [SI *đâu*]

*Tí think believe COMP ĐÂU PRT Tèo eat rice*

(48) \**Keoi man/soeng-zidou/jingwai* [John ***bindou*** wui gong daaiwaa].

*he ask/want-know/think John where will tell lie*

Intended: ‘He expressed that no way will John tell lies’ (Cheung 2008: 9)

(49) *Qual* a União Europeia (não) vai acabar.

*which the Union European (not) goes end-infin*

‘*Like hell the European Union will (not) come to an end.*’ (Martins 2021: 176)

Adopting Frey’s (2023) fine-grained categorization of root phenomena into weak and strong types, we categorize sentence-initial *đâu* as a strong root phenomenon due to its complete unembeddability. In contrast, POL-*đâu* exemplifies a weak root phenomenon, as it survives embedding by matrix non-factive predicates. POL-*đâu* thus neatly patterns with mood and modal elements of the left periphery. Sentence-initial *đâu*, however, behaves like pragmatic sentence-final particles, which strictly resist embedding (Phan 2024).<sup>30</sup> To foreshadow, *đâu* as two distinct sentence-final particles to be discussed in sections 3 and 4 also exhibits this syntactic constraint.

## 2.6 Summary

So far, we have shown that POL-*đâu* takes the widest scope, functioning as a negative marker heading the High Polarity Phrase above TP. It serves to reject the truth of a proposition *p* and can be felicitous in an out-of-the-blue context if an epistemic conflict concerning some *p* can be

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<sup>30</sup> We tentatively attribute the strong root-phenomenon nature of sentence-initial *đâu* to the involvement of a higher pragmatic domain above CP, where pragmatic information is encoded (see section 3). The encoding of pragmatic information occurs only in a root clause with an independent speech act (cf. Frey 2023), thus precluding embedding. As a working hypothesis, we assume that sentence-initial *đâu* is bound by a null illocutionary operator in the Speech Act Phrase (SAP) of this top domain (see section 4), which also explains its denial interpretation. A denial is “a speech act that objects to a previous utterance” (Repp 2009: 151). Since denial operates on the speech act level, it is distinct from negation marked with POL-*đâu*, which operates at the propositional level.

accommodated. POL-*đâu* is an instance of weak root phenomena, patterning with CP-level mood/modal elements in terms of embedding. POL-*đâu* is clearly distinguished from both *không* as a standard negator and sentence-initial *đâu* with a denial reading.

### 3. DEC-*đâu* and public commitment

The first instance of *đâu* in a sentence-final position is exclusively attested in declaratives, hence the mnemonic DEC-*đâu*. Although DEC-*đâu* is often likened to POL-*đâu*, we contend that it is distinct from negator *đâu* in both structural and interpretive terms. The former is situated high in the pragmatic domain above the traditional CP, signaling the speaker's wish to make it publicly known that she vouches for the negative proposition in the prejacent. DEC-*đâu* has an addressee-oriented dimension, as it must be used in a conversation with the necessary invocation of an addressee.<sup>31</sup> We paraphrase the pragmatic contribution of DEC-*đâu* with 'I'm telling you' in the translation.

#### 3.1 DEC-*đâu* ≠ POL-*đâu*

We contend that DEC-*đâu* is unrelated and cannot be compared to POL-*đâu* in both function and interpretation (*pace* Tran 2009; Duffield 2013; Trang Phan 2024). First, typological studies show that it is cross-linguistically very rare for VO languages to have sentence-final negators (cf. Reesink 2002; Dryer 2009). Second, there are contexts where only one of the two *đâu*'s is allowed. One such context is in (50): we see that DEC-*đâu* naturally occurs in a negative response to an imperative (50a), while POL-*đâu* cannot (50b).

(50) A: Ăn cơm!

eat rice

'Eat your rice!'

a. B: Em không ăn cơm *đâu*!

1SG NEG eat rice ĐÂU

'I'm not eating rice, *I'm telling you*!'

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<sup>31</sup> This includes cases of self-talk, i.e. linguistic interactions with oneself as the other interlocutor (Ritter & Wiltschko 2021).

b. B: \*Em *đâu* ăn cơm!

1SG ĐÂU eat rice

By uttering an imperative, the speaker commits herself to a preference, with the hope that the addressee takes on the commitment to realize her preference. In (50), the preference is for the addressee to eat his rice, which is itself not a proposition. This resonates with Truckenbrodt's (2006: 259) claim that imperatives "can never be interpreted as assertions, committing the speaker to the truth of a proposition, or asking the addressee to accept that truth."<sup>32</sup> This property renders it impossible to respond to an imperative with POL-*đâu* as in (50b), given that imperatives lack a proposition whose truth value POL-*đâu* could negate. (50a) is acceptable since the use of DEC-*đâu* allows the speaker to publicly endorse her own preference, that she does not commit herself to a future action according to the interlocutor's preference.

Another environment through which POL-*đâu* and DEC-*đâu* can be distinguished is the narrative context. (51) is an excerpt from a short story where the author simply narrates what happened without engaging in a conversation of any form. DEC-*đâu*, unlike POL-*đâu*, would be infelicitous in such a context, given that it requires the presence of an addressee in a conversation. Examples like (50) and (51) therefore show that it is misleading to treat DEC-*đâu* on a par with POL- *đâu*.

(51) Thy *đâu* biết mẹ buồn. Sáng nay mẹ không khỏe.<sup>33</sup>

Thy ĐÂU know mother sad morning this mother NEG well

'*It's untrue* that Thy knows her mother is unhappy. This morning the mother felt unwell.'

### 3.2 Sensitivity to polarity

We contend that the affinity between DEC-*đâu* and negative utterances, which leads many to consider DEC-*đâu* a negator, arises from the fact that the marker is sensitive to sentence negation. That is, DEC-*đâu* can only occur in declaratives that contain a sentence negator, be it *không* (52a)

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<sup>32</sup> Similarly, Boulat (2023: 26) observes that, in imperatives, "the speaker is not committed to the truth or the factuality of a proposition, but to the necessity of a course of action." Krifka (2018) proposes that imperatives denote a "bare proposition" which the speaker requires to become true in the future.

<sup>33</sup> <https://laodong.vn/lao-dong-cuoi-tuan/truyen-ngan-du-thi-phia-truoc-duong-con-xa-1197027.ldo>

or POL-*đâu* (52b). It is incompatible with constituent negator *không* (which takes scope under outer aspect), as in (53a), and with sentence-initial *đâu* (which is not a negator), as in (53b).

(52) a. Con không ăn cơm *đâu*.

TÍ NEG eat rice ĐÂU

‘Tí doesn’t eat rice, *I’m telling you.*’

b. Tí đâu ăn cơm *đâu*.

TÍ ĐÂU eat rice ĐÂU

‘It’s untrue that Tí eats rice, *I’m telling you.*’

(53) a. \*Tí đang không ăn cơm *đâu*.

TÍ DUR NEG eat rice ĐÂU

b. \*Đâu mà Tí ăn cơm *đâu*.

ĐÂU PRT TÍ eat rice ĐÂU

Importantly, DEC-*đâu* is not the only sentence-final element sensitive to sentence polarity.<sup>34</sup> (54) demonstrates that sentence-final *cơ* in a “corrective” context (cf. Nguyen 2021) behaves in the opposite manner to DEC-*đâu*: *cơ* is exclusively compatible with affirmative sentences.<sup>35</sup> Note that the pragmatic contribution of *cơ* in (54) is largely comparable to that of DEC-*đâu*, given that both mark the speaker’s endorsement of the prejacent. The key difference between them lies in the polarity value of their prejacent.

<sup>34</sup> DEC-*đâu* does not seem to be the only sentence-final particle with an affinity for negative polarity either. For instance, we find that Bena (a Bantu language spoken in Tanzania) exhibits a specialized marker *ka* whose syntactic behavior and interpretation strikingly resemble that of DEC-*đâu*. See (i) for an example. Sentence-final *ka* is only compatible with a negative sentence, marking the speaker’s disagreement with a previous discourse-prominent proposition. Like DEC-*đâu*, Bena *ka* also resists embedding. See Morrison (2011) for some other examples of this marker. A discussion on *ka* will not be pursued in this present work.

(i) A: wi wadz-a?

SUBJ.2SG come-FV.PRES.IMPF

‘You are coming?’

B: ni si wadz-a *ka*.

SUBJ.1SG NEG come-FV.PRES.IMPF KA

‘I am not coming, *I’m telling you.*’ (Grace Mayemba, p.c.)

<sup>35</sup> *Cơ* is generally assumed to be a variant of sentence-final *kia* (lit. ‘over there’), see Nguyen (2021).

(54) a. Tí không ăn cơm **đâu**/\***cơ**. [negative polarity]

Tí NEG eat rice ĐÂU CƠ

‘Tí doesn’t eat rice, *I’m telling you.*’

b. Tí ăn mì **\*đâu/cơ**. [affirmative polarity]

Tí eat noodle ĐÂU CƠ

‘Tí eats noodles, *I’m telling you.*’

Sentence-final particle *đây* (lit. ‘here’) behaves similarly to *cơ* with respect to its sensitivity to polarity. As shown in (55), *đây* only occurs with affirmative sentences, contrasting with DEC-*đâu*. We return to the contribution of sentence-final *đây* and *cơ* in section 3.3.

(55) a. Tí không ăn cơm **đâu**/\***đây**. [negative polarity]

Tí NEG eat rice ĐÂU SFP

‘Tí doesn’t eat rice, *I’m telling you.*’

b. Tí ăn mì **\*đâu/đây**. [affirmative polarity]

Tí like noodle ĐÂU SFP

‘Tí is eating noodles, *I think.*’

Note that it would also be problematic to assume that DEC-*đâu* is an NPI licensed by a negator. Evidence against this treatment comes from embedding facts. Recall that DEC-*đâu* does not survive embedding, see (51b). In contrast, an NPI like *chút nào* ‘at all’ can naturally occur in the same context, see (56). This discrepancy with respect to embedding rules out the possibility of DEC-*đâu* being an NPI.

(56) Tí nghĩ/ tin là Tèo không ăn **chút nào**.

Tí think believe COMP Tèo NEG ăn bit which

‘Tí thinks/believes that Tèo doesn’t eat *at all*.’

### 3.3 Public commitment and CommitP

If DEC-*đâu* is neither a negator nor an NPI, then what is it? Recall that DEC-*đâu* exhibits a similar embedding pattern to pragmatic sentence-final particles. Moreover, just like sentence-final *cơ* and *đây*, it is sensitive to sentence polarity. Notably, the three sentence-final elements share another feature: the speaker’s endorsement of their prejacent. For concreteness, *đây* as in

(55) essentially turns its host utterance into a conjecture, sparing the speaker from fully committing to the expressed proposition (Phan 2024). In contrast, when *cơ* appears in responses to declaratives (57), biased *yes-no* questions (58), or directives (59) with which the (affirmative) response must disagree, it marks the speaker’s full endorsement.

(57) A: *Tí ăn cơm.*

*Tí eat rice*

‘*Tí eats rice.*’

B: *Tí ăn mì cơ.*

*Tí eat noodle CƠ*

‘*Tí eats rice, I’m telling you.*’

(58) A: *Tí ăn cơm à?*

*Tí eat rice SFP*

‘*Tí eats rice?*’

B: *Tí ăn mì cơ.*

*Tí eat noodle CƠ*

‘*Tí eats rice, I’m telling you.*’

(59) A: *Ăn cơm!*

*eat rice*

‘*Eat your rice!*’

B: *Em ăn mì cơ!*

*1SG eat noodle CƠ*

‘*I eat noodles, I’m telling you!*’

Crucially, DEC-*đâu* also serves to endorse a statement that contradicts an initiating utterance in all these contexts (hence the same paraphrase), although this statement must always be in the negative form for DEC-*đâu*, see (60).

(60) *Tí/ em không ăn cơm đâu.*

*Tí 1SG NEG eat rice ĐÂU*

‘*Tí doesn’t eat rice/ I don’t eat rice, I’m telling you.*’

Interestingly enough, the two polarity-opposite responses that disagree with initiating utterances in (57-59) largely correspond to what Asher & Gillies (2003) term *correction* and *contradiction* as two types of disagreement in dialogue. Notice the now familiar pattern: correction is associated with affirmative polarity, as in (61); in contrast, a contradiction is marked with negative polarity, as in (62). We adopt these terms, stating that sentence-final *cơ* marks the speaker's endorsement of a correction, whereas DEC-*đâu* is used to endorse a contradiction. Both particles publicly communicate the speaker's disagreement with a previous propositional content to the addressee of a specific speech event.

(61) A: John distributed the copies.

B: No, it was Sue who distributed the copies. [Correction] (Asher & Gillies 2003: 488)

(62) A: John took first place.

B: No, he didn't. [Contradiction] (Asher & Gillies 2003: 488)

This characterization of DEC-*đâu* and *cơ* aligns with the description of pragmatic particles coalescing at the rightmost edge of the Vietnamese clause, a phenomenon ubiquitous in the language. Phan (2024) suggests that these particles syntactically merge in the topmost domain of the functional spine. The proposal of such a domain is pioneered by Speas & Tenny (2003) with their postulation of a Speech Act Phrase, a shell structure above the traditional CP.<sup>36</sup>

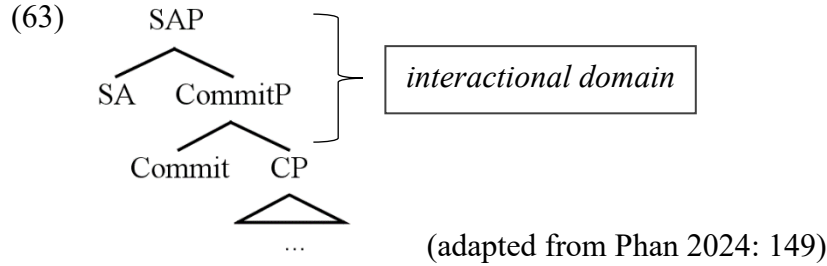
To account for the surface ordering of these sentence-final particles and the paradigms they form in distributional and interpretive terms, Phan (2024) hypothesizes for Vietnamese an articulated structure within this pragmatic domain, which consists of two projections.<sup>37</sup> The lower projection, termed Commitment Phrase (CommitP) following Krifka (2017, 2023), codifies how the propositional content is promoted and negotiated in a speech event. The higher projection, termed Speech Act Phrase (SAP), communicates the interaction between the speech participants. This dual-projection structure, illustrated in (63), is referred to as the *interactional*

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<sup>36</sup> This so-called “neo-performative” view ultimately traces back to Ross’s (1970) idea of a covert superordinate structure where illocutionary force is encoded by “performative” ditransitive verbs. The approach has gained much momentum in the past two decades, with a growing body of studies discussing data from a wide variety of languages (see also Hill 2007; Haegeman & Hill 2013; Tang 2015, i.a.).

<sup>37</sup> Phan (2024) takes each projection further split into two layers to accommodate a finer-grained analysis, a point we will gloss over in this study for simplicity’s sake.

*domain* (Wiltschko 2021), highlighting its interactional nature due to the necessary codification of information about the speaker and addressee. We discuss CommitP in the current section, leaving SAP for the next section.



CommitP is assumed to host information concerning the speaker’s public commitment towards a propositional content.<sup>38</sup> Public commitment is understood as anything available to both speech participants in the discourse context that the speaker “publicly treats as true for the purposes of the discourse” (Gunlogson 2008: 110). This kind of commitment has a clear social dimension: the speaker is expected to be consistent with her public endorsements (Gunlogson 2008) and is subject to social sanctions if the endorsed content is proven false (Krifka 2023). DEC-*đâu* provides exactly this kind of public commitment to the host utterance. While DEC-*đâu* is essentially optional, its presence explicitly communicates to the addressee that the speaker commits to the contradiction to a previous proposition or preference. This registers the contradiction for further negotiations and prevents the proposition/preference that the speaker contradicts from being added to the shared Common Ground (CG).<sup>39</sup> The pragmatic contribution of DEC-*đâu* leads us to assume its merge position in CommitP of the interactional domain.

For completeness’ sake, it is reasonable to also assume that sentence-final *cơ* and *đây* occupy the same merge position as DEC-*đâu*, given their function as either markers or modifiers of public commitment. *Cơ* marks the speaker’s commitment to a correction in a responding move, barring the contested proposition/preference to be admitted to CG. *Đây* modifies the strength of the speaker’s commitment in an initiating move, marking a conjecture to which the speaker does not fully commit (Phan 2024). Like DEC-*đâu*, both *cơ* and *đây* resist embedding, see (64). This resistance to embedding is characteristic of pragmatic particles in Vietnamese, as is now familiar.

<sup>38</sup> CommitP corresponds roughly to Wiltschko & Heim’s (2016) Grounding Phrase.

<sup>39</sup> The original conception of Common Ground goes back to Stalnaker (1974).

(64) \*Tí ngĩ/ tin là [Tèo không ăn cơm *co/ đây*].

Tí think believe COMP Tèo NEG eat rice CO SFP

### 3.4 Summary

We have argued in this section that sentence-final *đâu* in negative declaratives is neither a negator like POL-*đâu* nor an NPI. Instead, DEC-*đâu* is a pragmatic particle that merges high to the CommitP above CP, serving to mark the speaker's public commitment to a contradiction. It forms a paradigm with other commitment-marking/modifying particles like *co* and *đây*. All of these particles are sensitive to the polarity of their prejacent and resistant to embedding.

### 4. INT-*đâu* and call-on-addressee

As briefly mentioned in section 1, *đâu* can also appear sentence-finally in constituent questions. As shown below, it is the *wh*-expression to the left of INT-*đâu*, not INT-*đâu* itself, that is responsible for the interrogative construals.

(65) a. Tí gặp ai *đâu*?

Tí meet who ĐÂU

'Who did Tí meet? *Show me!*'

b. Tí ăn gì *đâu*?

Tí eat what ĐÂU

'What did Tí eat? *Show me!*'

c. Tí thích món nào *đâu*?

Tí walk dish which ĐÂU

'Which dish did Tí like? *Show me!*'

### 4.1 Preliminary observations

There are at least two pieces of evidence against treating INT-*đâu* in (65) as a genuine locative *wh*-word. First, although multiple *wh*-questions are possible in Vietnamese, if the location of an event is in question, *đâu* must be accompanied by the preposition *ở* 'at'. Compare (66) with (65a).

(66) Tí gặp ai ở *đâu*? [*đâu*: *wh*-word]

Tí meet who at ĐÂU

‘Who did Tí meet *where*?’

Second, for a grammatical sentence like (67), it is impossible for both instantiations of *đâu* to be genuine *wh*-words.

(67) Tí đi đâu *đâu*?

Tí go where ĐÂU

‘Where did Tí go? *Show me!*’

INT-*đâu* is also distinct from DEC-*đâu* in several key ways. First, the utterance hosting INT-*đâu* must be a question and cannot be interpreted as a contradiction to any previous proposition or preference. Additionally, INT-*đâu* occurs in an initiating move, while DEC-*đâu* is typically found in responding moves. As the paraphrases in (65) and (67) suggest, the presence of INT-*đâu* engages the addressee, obliging him to provide the missing information captured by the featured *wh*-word, typically through visual means. This pragmatic import of INT-*đâu* is particularly evident in identification questions, as shown in (68). Here, INT-*đâu* is infelicitous as the speaker does not expect a visual demonstration through which the addressee could identify himself. Conversely, consider a different scenario where a receptionist at a clinic asks a patient to identify himself by pointing to his name on an appointment list, probably due to the receptionist’s difficulty in matching the sound with the spelling of the patient’s ethnic name. In such a context, using INT-*đâu* in (68) is felicitous. Similarly, the speaker of (69) typically expects the addressee to visually demonstrate how the subject Tí walked, rather than simply providing a verbal account of his walking manner.

(68) Context: *A heard some loud noise outside. When she opened the door, she saw a complete stranger at her doorstep. A then asked...*

Anh là ai (*#đâu*)?

2SG be who ĐÂU

Int: ‘Who are you? *Show me!*’

(69) Tí đi sao *đâu*?

Tí walk how ĐÂU

‘How did Tí walk? *Show me!*’

This function of INT-*đâu* has a clear perlocutionary aspect, reminiscent of Beyssade & Marandin’s (2006) concept of *Call-on-Addressee*. Beyssade & Marandin (2006) contend that there are three types of call on the addressee in dialogue: the speaker can engage the addressee to take up her utterance as an assertion, a question, or a directive. We propose that INT-*đâu* specifically realizes a call on the addressee to interpret the utterance hosting it as a question and to visually provide the missing information represented by the corresponding *wh*-item.

If our characterization is on track, we expect that INT-*đâu* is incompatible with any question that lacks either a *wh*-element or a genuine information-seeking intent. The prediction is borne out as INT-*đâu* cannot appear in *yes/no* questions (70a), echo *wh*-questions (70b), or rhetorical questions (70c). *Yes/no* questions are out as they lack a *wh*-item, while echo *wh*-questions and rhetorical questions are not genuinely information-seeking: the former seek a confirmation or a repetition of “what was just said” (Karttunen 1977), and the latter do not expect the addressee to provide any answer by definition.

(70) a. Tí thích Tèo không (\**đâu*)? [*yes/no* question]

Tí like Tèo NEG ĐÂU

‘Does Tí like Tèo? \**Show me!*’

b. A: Tí thích Tèo.

Tí like Tèo

‘Tí likes Tèo’.

B: Tí thích ai (\**đâu*)? [echo *wh*-question]

Tí like who ĐÂU

‘Tí likes who? \**Show me!*’

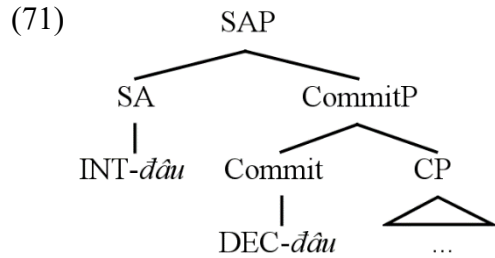
c. Tí mà thích ai (\**đâu*)! [rhetorical question]

Tí PRT like who ĐÂU

‘Tí doesn’t like anyone! \**Show me!*’

## 4.2 Call-on-addressee and SAP

Despite the obvious differences between DEC-*đâu* and INT-*đâu*, both possess an interactional dimension (Wiltchko 2021) as they necessarily involve exchanges of information between the participants in a speech event. The presence of the speech participants is prominent with INT-*đâu*, as it encodes the speaker's expectation regarding how the addressee should respond to her inquiry. Consequently, it is reasonable to assume that INT-*đâu* also belongs to the pragmatic domain, similar to DEC-*đâu*. However, INT-*đâu* should merge in a distinct projection since it does not concern the speaker's public commitment to a propositional content. Instead, it focuses on how the speaker engages and interacts with the addressee for the purposes of the conversation. Due to its specific pragmatic import, we propose that INT-*đâu* merges in the higher Speech Act Phrase (SAP), aligning with the conceptualization of the interactional domain discussed in section 3.<sup>40</sup> (71) illustrates the structural positioning of INT-*đâu* and DEC-*đâu* within the syntactic spine.



Since INT-*đâu* and DEC-*đâu* are associated with different clause types (the former pairs with interrogatives, the latter with declaratives), they naturally cannot co-occur. Nonetheless, a hierarchical structure such as (71), with distinct projections corresponding to different types of pragmatic import, is evidenced in Vietnamese through the rigid linear ordering of sentence-final particles when they appear in clusters. (72) exemplifies two such ordered co-occurrences, each with either DEC-*đâu* or *cơ* (dubbed DEC-*cơ* henceforth) linearly preceding *mà*.<sup>41</sup>

<sup>40</sup> SAP roughly corresponds to Wiltchko & Heim's (2016) Response Phrase, understood as a projection dedicated to codifying what the speaker wants the addressee to perform with the current utterance.

<sup>41</sup> See chapter 5 of Phan 2024 and citations therein for more examples of particle clusters in Vietnamese.

(72) a. Tí không thích Tèo {đâu} mà {\*đâu}.

Tí NEG like Tèo ĐÂU PRT ĐÂU

‘Tí doesn’t like Tèo. *I’m telling you, trust me.*’

b. Tí thích Tèo {cơ} mà {\*cơ}.

Tí like Tèo CƠ PRT CƠ

‘Tí likes Tèo. *I’m telling you, trust me.*’

In section 3, we suggested that DEC-*đâu* and DEC-*cơ* exhibit parallelism in both interpretation and syntactic position, as they both serve as commitment-marking devices. That they are required to appear to the left of *mà* consolidates the intuition about their similarity in merge position. Furthermore, their rigid ordering relative to *mà* is telling of a scopal relation: *mà* in (72) necessarily scopes over the two commitment-markers, serving to persuade the addressee to accept as true a propositional content (in the form of either a contradiction or a correction) to which the speaker publicly commits. This characterization allows us to group *mà* with INT-*đâu* in the same category of call-on-addressee markers in SAP.

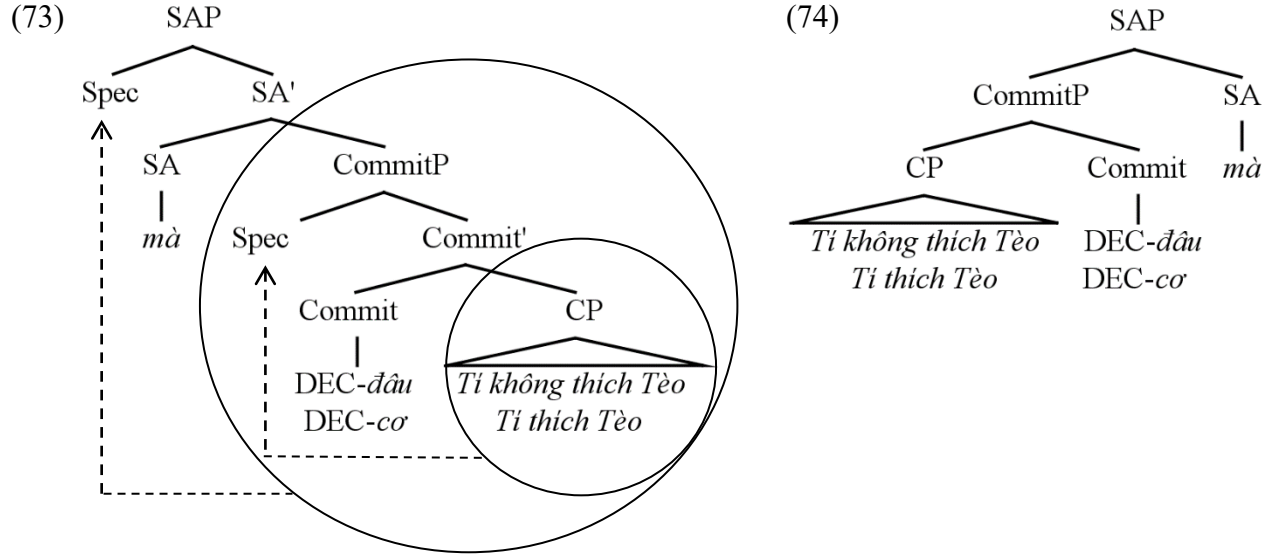
A brief note on the linear placement of sentence-final particles is in order. As far as pragmatic particles in Vietnamese are concerned, the element further to the right takes wide scope over what is to its left, as shown in (72). This is the mirror image of what is uniformly observed for CP-internal elements. For example, recall that POL-*đâu* both scopes over and precedes a tense marker, which in turn scopes over and precedes negator *không*. Roughly two analyses have been proposed to account for this “reverse” linear placement of pragmatic particles cross-linguistically.<sup>42</sup>

One analysis assumes a head-initiality of projections across categories, deriving the linear order of sentence-final particles relative to each other and to the preadjacent through successive comp-to-spec movement in a “roll-up” fashion (cf. Hsieh & Sybesma 2011, a.o.), see (73). The other analysis posits that sentence-final particles are part of a separate domain and thus can be head-final while elements of lower domains remain head-initial (see Erlewine 2017), as illustrated in (74). Regardless, both analyses can account for why a pragmatic particle further to the right always takes wider scope. The issue of head-directionality of Vietnamese sentence-final

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<sup>42</sup> See Phan (2024) for an overview of these competing analyses.

particles goes beyond the scope of the current study and will not be pursued here. We present the syntax tree for the interactional domain as right-branching throughout the current work solely for convenience's sake.



### 4.3 Calls can be diverse and specific

Recall that Beyssade & Marandin (2006) assume the speaker can call on the addressee to take up her utterance as an assertion, a question, or a directive and act accordingly. The discussion of INT-*đâu* and *mà* above shows that a speaker's calls in languages can be a lot more diverse and specific. With INT-*đâu*, the speaker expects the addressee to visually provide the missing information captured by a *wh*-item. *Mà*, on the other hand, acts to persuade the addressee to accept the speaker's proposition as true or to ensure that the speaker's preference becomes true.

Interestingly enough, just as *đâu* can be either a call-on-addressee marker or a marker of public commitment, we can also find instances of particle *cơ* in both CommitP and SAP. *Cơ* as part of SAP is typically found in echo *wh*-questions, see (75) for an example. Given that this instantiation of *cơ* only occurs in interrogatives, similar to INT-*đâu*, we refer to it as INT-*cơ* henceforth. As the paraphrase suggests, INT-*cơ* serves to mark the speaker's call for the addressee to either restate or reconfirm some portion of his previous utterance due to the speaker's failure, for whatever reason, to fully register what was expressed by the interlocutor.

(75) A: Tí thích Tèo.

Tí like Tèo

‘Tí likes Tèo’.

B: Tí thích ai cơ?

Tí like who cơ

‘Tí likes who? *Say it again.*’

What is more, such special requests are also attested in other languages.<sup>43</sup> For example, Sauerland (2009) and Sauerland & Yatsushiro (2017) propose that the German particle *noch mal* ‘again’ in (76a) and the Japanese specialized particle *kke* in (76b) convey a specific *remind-me* reading of a question, which can be roughly paraphrased as ‘I used to know your name, but forgot. Could you remind me what your name is?’ (Sauerland & Yatsushiro 2017: 651-2). Similar to the cases of INT-*đâu* and INT-*cơ*, German *noch mal* and Japanese *kke* are restricted to interrogatives.<sup>44</sup> They are not question markers themselves, although their *remind-me* reading is dependent on the question sentence-type.

(76) a. Wie ist ***noch mal*** Ihr Name?

how is again your name

‘What is your name *again*?’ (adapted from Sauerland & Yatsushiro 2017: 651-2)

b. Namae-wa nan da-***kke***-ka?

name-TOP what COP-KKE-Q

‘What is your name *again*?’ (Sauerland & Yatsushiro 2017: 658)

Syntactically, Sauerland & Yatsushiro (2017) claim that German *noch mal* and Japanese *kke* merge high in the left periphery, taking scope over a common ground projection that constitutes the question speech act. Dayal (2023) explicitly places Japanese *kke* in Speas & Tenny’s (2003)

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<sup>43</sup> Wiltchko & Heim (2016) also claim that the final particle *eh* with a rising contour in Canadian English serves to request the addressee to confirm either the truth of the speaker’s current proposition (ia) or that the addressee already knows the proposition to be true (ib).

(i) a. I have a new dog, *eh*?

b. You have a new dog, *eh*?

<sup>44</sup> The *remind-me* reading in German is also exclusively compatible with constituent questions. The same is not true for Japanese, however.

SAP, the locus for contextual coordinates such as the speech participants. In this top position, these particles oblige the addressee to remind the speaker of a piece of information previously contributed to the common ground, resulting in the *remind-me* reading. This characterization largely parallels the proposed function of Vietnamese call-on-addressee particles like INT-*đâu*. Due to its high merge position in SAP, INT-*đâu* also scopes over the projection codifying public commitments, where the shared common ground is negotiated.

Finally, all these call-on-addressee markers exhibit similar behavior concerning embedding: ungrammaticality ensues when they occur in embedded clauses, see (77-79) for illustration. This restriction is unsurprising given the high structural position they occupy in the functional spine.

(77) Wer hat {*noch mal*} erzählt, dass sie {\**noch mal*} Tamilisch kann?  
 who has again narrated that she again Tamil can  
 ‘Remind me: Who said that she knows Tamil?’ (Sauerland & Yatsushiro 2017: 662, quoted with minor modifications)

(78) \*Doko-ni simatta-*kke* siri-tai desu?  
 where-LOC put.away-KKE know-want COP  
 Int: ‘[I] want to know, “where did [I] put [the keys] *again*?”’ (Sauerland & Yatsushiro 2017: 658)

(79) \*Tôi muốn biết [Tí thích ai *đâu/ cơ*].  
 1SG want know Tí like who ĐÂU CƠ  
 Int: ‘I want to know who Tí likes, *show me/ say it again*.’

#### 4.4 Summary

This section argues that INT-*đâu* is not a locative *wh*-expression despite its affinity with *wh*-interrogatives. Its occurrence explicitly marks the speaker’s request for the addressee to treat the current utterance as a question and provide the exact information that the speaker asks for through some visual means. This pragmatic import makes it a particle of the high SAP within the interactional domain. INT-*đâu* is therefore distinct from DEC-*đâu* in terms of both pragmatic import and structural position.

## 5. Conclusion

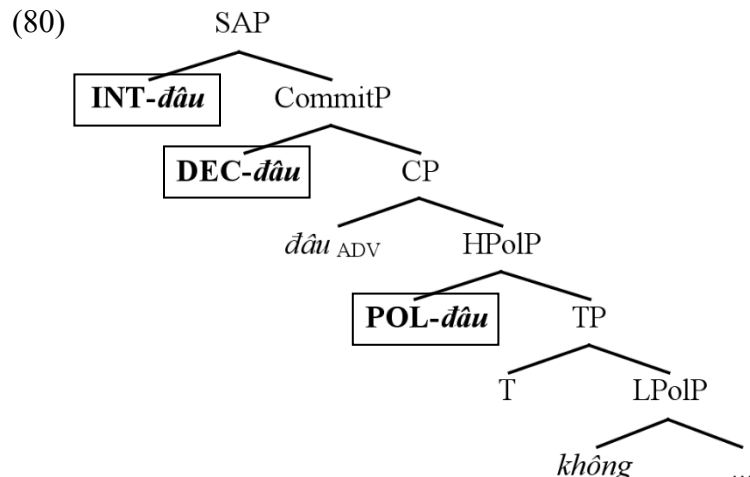
The inspiration for this study stems from our interest in accounting for the various occurrences of *đâu*, which are scattered throughout a Vietnamese clause structure. We focus on the syntactic and interpretive attributes of *đâu*, functioning either as a pre-verbal negator (POL-*đâu*) or as a sentence-final particle (i.e., DEC-*đâu* and INT-*đâu*). The phenomena have received little or no attention in the existing literature.

Linear orders and scopal relations indicate that POL-*đâu* merges above tense markers, while standard negator *không* merges below them. This effectively argues for two structurally distinct polarity projections in Vietnamese: POL-*đâu* is part of a TP-external projection, i.e., High Polarity Phrase, serving to falsify a discourse-prominent proposition or cancel an inference. In contrast, *không* heads a TP-internal projection, i.e., Low Polarity Phrase, which negates the untensed main predicate, indicating that the predicate does not hold of its subject. Furthermore, sentence-initial *đâu* should be distinguished from POL-*đâu*: The former is not a negator due to its inability to license NPIs, whereas the latter merges high in CP, functioning as an adverb to deny a previous utterance.

As a sentence-final particle, DEC-*đâu* is also quite different from POL-*đâu*, despite its exclusive compatibility with negative declaratives. Its sensitivity to wide-scope polarity is attributed to its function as a marker of public commitment. Namely, its presence publicly commits the speaker to a contradiction (i.e. a disagreement in the negative form) to a propositional content. In contrast, sentence-final INT-*đâu* is compatible only with constituent questions. Its presence obliges the addressee to answer the speaker's current question, typically by visually showing the information under inquiry.

DEC-*đâu* and INT-*đâu* are assumed to merge in two separate projections within the interactional domain. DEC-*đâu* is part of the lower Commitment Phrase, while INT-*đâu* takes a wider scope as part of the higher Speech Act Phrase. Both particles exhibit resistance to embedding, in stark contrast to POL-*đâu*, which may occur inside the complement of non-factive predicates.

A cartographic map of the three instantiations of *đâu* is roughly sketched out in (80).



To sum up, our findings and the cartographic analysis presented above shed light on the functional architecture of the Vietnamese clause, especially on the area beyond TP, an area largely unexplored so far in the literature. We demonstrate that *đâu* does not simply pattern with *what*-like expressions such as *gì* and *sao* in non-information-seeking questions (Phan & Tsai 2022), but also serves as a high negator and two markers of pragmatic relations. The latter functions are not normally associated with *wh*-elements cross-linguistically. This study thus contributes to the growing body of research aimed at providing a more comprehensive account of non-canonical *wh*-construals across languages.

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